

Combat

Combat in Tales Untold is fast, positional, and decisive. Turns are short. Mistakes compound. The goal is not to outlast — it's to outread.

Core Combat Philosophy

Three things decide a fight, and a build's stance toward all three, together, is what actually gets read:

- **Balance between the three stats** — Mind, Body, and Soul (`rules/character-creation.md`). Every color answers another: red overwhelms green, green outlasts blue, blue unmakes red. No stat is strongest on its own; a deck built around one alone is legible, countered risk, not a winning strategy. Mechanically, this is what **RPS** means throughout this document — the color triangle, resolved through stat balance.
- **Control distance.** Frontline and Backline. Some things only work up close; some only work at range. Moving between them costs the action you'd have spent doing something else. Shorthand: **Position**.
- **Act before your opponent does.** The initiative wheel, not a fixed turn order — shifting where you sit in it is one of the few ways to act again before the table would otherwise expect you to. Shorthand: **Initiative**.

RPS / Initiative / Position is the shorthand used throughout this ruleset for the three above. **A build that ignores one entirely takes on real, legible risk — fine, as long as it's intentional, not accidental.** Most real builds carry at least one tool against at least one of the three; a card or engine that looks unanswerable in a given test needs to be checked against whether that specific build had a tool for the pillar it's actually being asked to answer, before it's read as overtuned rather than matchup-specific.

Default to telegraphed effects over hidden ones. A hidden delayed payoff is just a surprise; a visible one is a real bet the opponent gets a turn to answer it. When a new mechanic could go either way on visibility, give the other side a chance to react — don't default to concealment for its own sake.

Stealth & Ambush

To approach unseen before combat, make a check: $DC = 10 + \text{the highest Soul stat on the enemy side}$. Players perceive an ambush the same way — $DC = 10 + \text{the highest Soul stat on the enemy side}$.

On success: The ambusher's first attack auto-hits — no RPS, no defense. After it resolves, roll initiative for everyone involved, including the ambusher. They take their place in order normally. Combat begins.

On failure: Roll initiative. No advantage.

Chase

When a character flees and the pursuer gives chase, set up a two-marker track instead of repeating checks.

Set up: Estimate how many exchanges of movement currently separate them — that's the fleeing party's starting position. The pursuer starts at 0. Standard track is 5 steps past the fleeing party's start; extend it if the head start is larger.

Example: right on your heels = both at 0, track runs to 5. A full corridor away = fleeing party at 3, pursuer at 0, track runs to 8.

Each exchange (6 seconds): Contested Soul roll ($2d10 + \text{Soul}$). The winner advances their marker 1 step. Discard a card whose name fits the action → Advantage.

Caught — The pursuer's marker reaches the fleeing party's marker.

Escaped — The fleeing party's marker reaches the end of the track. They've maintained enough distance to lose sight. The pursuer may attempt to follow the trail afterward (Reason check, DC set by GM based on terrain and time elapsed).

Fleeing Combat

Exiting combat mid-fight is an action: $2d10 + \text{Soul}$ vs $\text{DC} = 10 + \text{the highest Soul stat among enemy combatants}$ — the ambush formula, run from the other side. Soul gets you into fights unseen and gets you out of them alive.

The formula is the baseline, not the answer. The GM adjusts it for the factors it can't see:

- **Terrain** — open road vs briar walls vs a corridor with one door
- **What stands between you and out** — an enemy in your path is not an abstraction
- **Position** — Backline is closer to gone than Frontline
- **Whether the enemy cares** — a territorial creature that just wants you off its ground may make the check trivial, or unnecessary; a hunter in its own territory pushes it up

Success: you leave the combat area and your participation ends. If the enemy gives chase, that's the Chase system above.

Failure: the action is spent and you're still in the fight, exactly where everyone can see you.

Enemies don't roll to flee — enemy disengagement is a GM call made from behavior, not a check.

Initiative

At the start of combat, each participant rolls:

$1d6 + \text{Soul}$

Turn order resolves highest to lowest.

Soul and not Body, on purpose. Body is physical speed — ground covered and force delivered. **Soul is reflex**, and reflex here means the read rather than the twitch: who was already moving before the thing happened

(rules/character-creation.md, What Stats Do). A high-Body character gets there first. A high-Soul character was already going.

Ties:

- Higher Soul goes first.
- If still tied between players, they choose order among themselves.
- If still tied between a player and an enemy, the player goes first.

The Wheel. Tokens are placed clockwise around the wheel in initiative order — whoever goes first sits at 12 o'clock. A turn marker starts at 12 o'clock. Each turn, the marker moves to the next token in line.

The wheel always has exactly as many slots as there are combatants — no empty slots. When a token shifts, each token it passes through slides over one slot toward the gap the moving token leaves behind.

Joining and leaving. A summoned combatant's token enters the wheel directly after the token of whoever summoned it. A GM-introduced combatant enters when the fiction calls for it — usually at the end of a full lap. Either way, the wheel gains a slot. A combatant who leaves the fight entirely removes their slot, and the wheel closes around it.

Turn Structure

When initiative is rolled, every combatant draws to their maximum hand size — nobody enters the wheel empty-handed.

At the start of your turn, draw until you reach your maximum hand size. If your deck is empty, shuffle your discard pile into a new deck before drawing.

On your turn, you may take one Action, plus one free action if you have one available (see below).

ACTION	DESCRIPTION
Play a Card	Make an attack using a card from your hand
Move Position	Shift between Frontline and Backline — or, if you're already Frontline, close the distance on a Backline enemy yourself instead (Rushdown: you move to them, not the reverse). See Positioning → Rushdown.
Use an Item	Activate an equipped or held item, or use a consumable
Take Cover	Backline only; the fiction must justify it. Gain Cover Evade — a dodge roll that persists instead of being spent. See Positioning → Cover.
Interact	Any noncombat action — talk, examine, activate, manipulate, or anything the fiction allows
Flee	Attempt to exit combat — 2d10 + Soul vs DC 10 + highest enemy Soul, GM-adjusted. See Fleeing Combat above.

Free Actions. Once per turn, on top of your Action above, you get one free action — it costs nothing from your turn, so you still take your normal Action as well. Spending a banked Quick to Move Position (Rushdown included), activating a

piece of your own gear (turning something on, and similar minor personal gestures — not the world around you; that's still Interact), and eating or drinking all count. Capped at one per turn regardless of how many you'd otherwise have available — a second banked Quick just waits for next turn.

Actually using a consumable or piece of gear for its mechanical effect is never free — that's Use an Item, above, and costs your Action. Kevin throwing an incendiary orange is Use an Item: the throw's whole point is the effect it produces, not a minor gesture.

Reading a Card

Every card carries: **Name / Color + Stat / Attack (Stat + die) / Effect / Defense Effect / Range / Flavor text.**

The die tells you the card's philosophy:

DIE	PERSONALITY
d8	Raw power — high ceiling, less control
d6	Utility — moderate damage, strong effects
d4	Precision — low damage, high control and information

(d10 shows up on a handful of cards as a genuine outlier above this scale — rare, and usually paired with an extra cost or condition.)

Some cards carry a **Special Rule** line instead of — or alongside — an Effect and a Defense Effect. It overrides normal resolution exactly as printed.

"Attacker"/"Defender" vs. "Target" — two different things on card text:

- **Attacker/Defender** means whoever you're resolving *this specific exchange* against. No choice involved.
- **Target** means you genuinely choose — an ally among several, or a specific enemy when more than one is present.

An Example — STRIKE

```
STRIKE
RED — BODY
Attack: Body + d10
Effect: None
Defense Effect: Deal 3 damage to attacker, unpreventable.
Range: Melee
"Sometimes the direct path is the wisest path."
```

- **Name** — STRIKE.
- **Color + Stat** — Red, Body. A Red card beats Green and loses to Blue in RPS, and its damage comes off your Body stat.

- **Attack: Body + d10** — your Body stat plus a d10 roll. The fourth tier, and the rarest: Red alone holds it, on cards that pay for it somewhere else on the card (STRIKE has no Effect at all, REPAY costs 3 HP up front, OVERCOMMIT hands you Vulnerable for the privilege).
- **Effect: None** — nothing happens beyond the damage when you win as the attacker. This is what STRIKE actually trades for that big die: every other d10 card in the game still does something extra — bonus damage under a condition, a reposition, a resource interaction — STRIKE's whole design is spent on the number alone.
- **Defense Effect: Deal 3 damage to attacker, unpreventable** — win *or tie* as the defender and you deal a flat 3 back (STRIKE's own Effect is None, so it never cancels the Defense Effect on a tie). "Unpreventable" means it skips the Damage Pipeline entirely — Resist, Protect, none of it applies.
- **Range: Melee** — you and your target must both be in the Frontline to play this card.
- **Flavor text** — *"Sometimes the direct path is the wisest path."* Not a rule. Just the world's own read on a card built with nothing to hide.

Full canonical wording for every keyword and status card: `rules/card-glossary.md`.

A Passive resolves exactly like a card from hand once concealment is settled — what it is, its fixed shape, and how it's concealed beforehand: `rules/character-creation.md`, Passives.

Attack Resolution

1. Attacker plays 1 card, face down — committed, not yet public.
2. Defender may choose 1 card to defend with, face down — **The chosen card must satisfy its own Range requirement for the current positions, exactly as if the defender were attacking the attacker** — a Melee card cannot defend unless both combatants are Frontline; Ranged and Both are unaffected.
3. **Blind and Evade resolve now, before either card is revealed.** Both cards are already committed at this point. Every check that applies actually rolls — being attacked is what triggers a defender's Evade and Blind, not whether the attack would land, so a stack gets spent, or a defender's own block-miss gets rolled, even when it turns out not to have mattered:

- **Attacker's Blind:** roll 1d2 if the attacker holds it. - **Defender's Evade:** roll 1d2 if the defender holds it. - **Defender's Blind:** roll 1d2 if the defender holds it and is actually defending.

Resolving the rolls, in this order: 1. **Defender's Evade succeeds** → the defender auto-wins the resolution (step 5's Defender wins outcome). A clean dodge — nothing else in this step changes that. 2. **Otherwise, attacker's Blind misses and defender's Blind misses** → **Mutual Miss** (see step 5): the attack failed and the block attempted against it also failed. Not a win for either side, and not a Tie — a Tie still needs two cards that actually did something; this is two that didn't. 3. **Otherwise, attacker's Blind misses alone** (the defender's own block, if any, didn't also miss) → the defender auto-wins the resolution. 4. **Otherwise, defender's Blind misses alone** (the attacker's own attack, above, didn't also miss) → the attacker wins automatically, exactly like no legal defense, below. 5. **Otherwise** (none of the above fired) → proceed to the reveal.

A mistaken illegal pick (wrong Range for the current positions) is fixed differently depending on when it's caught. Caught before the attacker's card is known: swap freely, no penalty — nothing about the attacker's choice has leaked, so

the pick is still genuinely blind. Caught only after the attacker's card is already revealed: too late for a free redo, since that knowledge can't be un-known and picking again now would mean picking with information blind defense is supposed to deny you. Resolve it as no legal defense — but the illegal card itself returns to hand, not the discard pile, since it was never actually, legally played. The attacker still learns what it was (a real cost, already paid), but the mistake doesn't also cost a card on top of the auto-loss.

1. If the defender cannot or chooses not to defend, the attacker wins automatically — same outcome as a defender Blind-miss, above.
2. Both cards reveal simultaneously — only now do they become public and move to their owners' discard piles — and resolve using Rock-Paper-Scissors:

Blue (Mind)	beats	Red (Body)
Red (Body)	beats	Green (Soul)
Green (Soul)	beats	Blue (Mind)

Attacker wins → deal damage, then apply the card's Effect **Defender wins** → no damage + defender triggers Defense Effect **Tie** → no damage. Attacker's Effect still triggers, then Defender's Defense Effect triggers. If the attacker's Effect cancels the Defense Effect, the Defense Effect does not trigger. **Mutual Miss** → no damage, no Effect, no Defense Effect. Both cards are still discarded as normal — they were played, they just both failed. Only reachable via the attacker's Blind and the defender's Blind both missing in the same exchange (step 3, above); it never comes up during a normal reveal.

An Effect that only *adds to or amplifies this attack's damage* has nothing to act on when the attack deals no damage — so it does nothing on a tie (or any miss). Exploding dice, "+2 damage this attack," "deal +2 for each Wound," and the like all need a landed hit. Effects that do something independent of attack damage — apply a status, shift a stat, move a card — still trigger normally.

A standing bonus or penalty like "your next attack deals +X" is consumed by a miss.

Damage Pipeline

The base roll is **Stat + die, with Deadly/Weak folded in** — a Deadly stack adds a d6, a Weak stack subtracts one, and one of each cancels before either applies. That total is what enters the pipeline below.

When *attack* damage is dealt, it passes through this pipeline in fixed order:

reassignment (the damage lands on someone else instead, in full, before anything reduces it — Protect volunteers you for an ally's hit; TURN sends an attack you're defending against at a target of your choice) → **Immunity** (held by whoever is actually receiving the damage — reduces it to 0, leaving the rest of the pipeline nothing to act on) → **Armour** (flat reduction) → **Resist / Vulnerable** (one stack of each cancels the other first; otherwise Resist halves or Vulnerable multiplies by 1.5, rounded down) → apply to HP.

A single attack cannot push a *standing* combatant below 0 HP (clamped to 0 = Collapse; see Collapse & Death below).

Unpreventable damage bypasses this pipeline entirely — not as an exception carved out of it, but because the pipeline only ever governed *attack* damage in the first place. Thorns, status damage, and HP costs are not attacks, so none of the steps above apply: they cannot be reduced (Resist) or reassigned (Protect). They land on the original target, in full. Thorns specifically retaliates against a melee attacker after the hit lands, and is itself unpreventable.

Range

Every card lists a range requirement. If you don't meet it, you cannot play that card as an attack this turn.

TERM	MEANING
Melee	You and the target must be in the Frontline
Ranged	Works only while not in Melee range with the target
Both	Either position is valid

Positioning

Every combatant occupies one of two positions: **Frontline** or **Backline**.

Frontline isn't a fixed place on the field — it's wherever two sides have actually closed the distance and are fighting face to face. Whoever's caught up in that is Frontline, on both sides of it, for as long as it's happening there; that contact point is where Melee range exists. Backline is everyone else: still in the fight, just not closed with anyone yet. Nothing pins the Frontline to one spot — it's wherever the fighting actually is, and it moves when the fighting does.

Both positions are abstract zones, and any number of characters may occupy either one. What occupying the same position *means* depends on which side of the fight you're on.

Same position, same side — together. Everyone sharing a position with their own side is beside each other: close enough to hand something over, step in front of each other, pass a drink. This is equally true of a group of enemies. Opponents sharing a position are bunched together on their own side of the field, which is what lets an effect that hits *every enemy in a position* land on all of them at once.

Same position, opposite sides — only the Frontline puts you in reach. The Frontline is the contact point, so everyone there is closed with everyone there, on both sides of it. The Backline is not a place; it's the state of not being closed with the enemy, and each side has its own. Two opponents who are both in the Backline are across the field from each other, which is why Backline-to-Backline is not Melee range.

So a card can pass a drink to an ally in your position while a Melee card cannot reach an enemy in yours — and an orange thrown into the enemy Backline still catches everyone standing in it.

A position is a designation, not a patch of ground. Anything placed at a position — a glyph, a seed, a lingering hazard — catches whoever occupies that position, not whoever steps on one particular spot.

Moving costs your action for the turn. Position provides no automatic protection. The Frontline does not shield the Backline from being targeted.

Range Matrix

Position determines which cards can be played. Use this table to resolve any targeting question:

ATTACKER	TARGET	MELEE	RANGED	BOTH
Frontline	Frontline	✓	✗	✓
Frontline	Backline	✗	✓	✓
Backline	Frontline	✗	✓	✓
Backline	Backline	✗	✓	✓

Melee requires both characters to be in the Frontline. Any other combination is not Melee range.

Rushdown

The Move Position action's other shape, not a separate action of its own: closing the distance on a Backline **enemy** yourself, instead of shifting between Frontline and Backline — not moving them, moving toward them. Wherever you land, that's Frontline now, for both of you: the fighting bent to include them, not a teleport. Cannot target allies. You must already be in the Frontline yourself — Rushdown extends a fight you're already inside, not a first step into one from nothing. See Move Position in the action table, above.

Rooted and Rushdown. Rooted cancels a Rushdown you make, the same as any other movement of your own, and is spent doing it (rules/card-glossary.md , Rooted). It does **not** save the target from being caught up in one: they did not change position, the line did. Their Rooted is still there and still unspent afterward. Being reached is not the same as being moved.

Interact & Position

Position determines what's within reach. A character can only interact with objects that the fiction places near them. The GM calls it based on where things are — a lever at the center of the room favors Frontline characters, a mechanism on the back wall favors Backline. Neither position has a blanket advantage; the environment decides.

Cover

Taking cover is an action. You must be in the Backline, and the fiction must justify it — there must be something to take cover behind.

While in cover you have **Cover Evade** — its own thing, not the Evade keyword, though it rolls identically. The same 1d2 dodge at the same point in Attack Resolution (step 3), succeeding the same way, with the one difference that matters: **it is not a stack and is never spent**. Every attack against you rolls it, however many come, for as long as you hold cover.

Cover ends the instant you attack. It also ends if you leave the Backline, or if the fiction takes the cover away — a wall comes down, the thing you were behind moves. Cover Evade goes with it.

Cover Evade and held Evade stacks are separate. Only one dodge roll happens per attack, so if you have both, the cover roll is the one that happens and your stacks stay banked for after cover breaks. That is the point of paying an Action for cover rather than a card: the stacks you were holding survive it.

Confined Spaces

In tight environments (narrow tunnels, low passages, cramped rooms), the GM may limit how many characters fit in either position. If a creature physically blocks a passage, characters behind them cannot be targeted unless the fiction clearly allows it (e.g., ranged attack with line of sight). Rushdown in confined spaces may represent forcing an enemy into unstable terrain rather than a clean positional shift.

Ongoing Effects

Some cards produce **Ongoing Effects**. These cards remain face up in front of the player after use. The effect persists until its stated condition is met, at which point the card is discarded.

Multiple ongoing effects can be active simultaneously unless a card specifies otherwise.

Setting one up before the fight

A character who has time and a reason may set up one Ongoing Effect before initiative is rolled. One, not two. They play the card, it goes face up in front of them, and the fight starts with it already running.

What "time and a reason" means is the ordinary table judgement: they knew something was coming, they were not surprised, and they said so before the GM called for initiative. A party that has smelled a Foulhaul on the wind (`bestiary/foulhaul.md`), watched a light refuse to move, or spent the evening deciding to kick a door has all three. A party walking round a corner into something has none of them.

The cap is the whole rule. Preparation should be worth doing and should never turn into a stacking exercise where the fight is decided before anyone rolls. One card, set before initiative, and everything after that is paid for in Actions like normal.

This also rewards the exploration layer directly: warnings are worth having because a warning is worth exactly one Ongoing Effect.

Objects

Some things stand on the field without being combatants. A summoned spirit, a totem, a wall somebody made out of themselves, a seed. They are on the table and they can be destroyed, but they are not people taking turns.

An Object:

- **Holds HP and nothing else.** No stats, no deck, no hand, no Passives.
- **Takes no turn and gets no token on the initiative wheel.** The rule that puts a summoned combatant into the wheel (Initiative, above) does not apply, because an Object is not a combatant.

- **Never acts or decides anything**, including on the turn it arrives.
- **Occupies a position** and is caught by anything that catches a position.
- **Can be attacked directly**. An enemy may target it instead of a person.
- **Is auto-hit when attacked**. It holds no cards, so it cannot choose a defence, and an attack on a target that cannot or will not defend already resolves without an RPS reveal (Attack Resolution, above). This is that rule, not a new one.
- **Does not Collapse and is never Down**. At 0 HP it is simply gone, and anything it was holding up goes with it.
- **Does not count for whether a side is still standing**. A party is not still in the fight because its totem is.

Where an Object's HP comes from is the card's business. A spirit rolls for it (`campaign/pat.md` , Wild Magic Summoning). A structure or a seed made out of a character is paid for out of that character's own HP pool and holds exactly what they paid (`campaign/passives.md` , AMALGAMOUS FORM; `campaign/chris.md` , Seeds) — which is what makes destroying one a real loss rather than a nuisance.

Track an Object with the card that made it, face up in front of its owner, the same technique Ongoing Effects and status tokens already use. One card, one Object: the card is what says the thing is there, and it goes to the discard when the thing does.

Written 2026-09-20, off three examples rather than one — Pat's spirits, AMALGAMOUS FORM's walls, and Chris's seeds. Both of the first two sheets said in as many words that the category was worth generalising once there was more than a single case of it, and declined to do it early.

Simultaneous Effects

When two or more effects would resolve at the same moment — several "start of your turn" triggers, two tokens landing at once — the **controller of those effects chooses the order** they resolve in. If the simultaneous effects have different controllers, the player whose turn it is decides the order.

Order can matter: two ticks that commute end at the same number, but a heal that arrives after a lethal tick arrives too late. If two effects would each reduce a combatant to death at the same instant and neither is clearly first, the exchange is a **mutual result** — resolve it as a tie.

This does not apply to Attack Resolution. An attacker's Effect and a defender's Defense Effect are not a controller's choice to order — Attack Resolution (above) already fixes it: Effect before Defense Effect, always, on every tie. Nobody, including the attacker, chooses that order.

You Are Not Your Own Ally

Card effects that say "allies" or "enemies" never include yourself. You can't target yourself with an ally effect, and you can't accidentally trigger an enemy effect on yourself. "All allies in your position" means everyone else sharing it — not you. The only exception is a card that explicitly names *yourself* as the target.

Collapse & Death

If an attack reduces you to **0 HP**, you Collapse.

- A single attack cannot push you below 0.
- Additional damage taken while Collapsed *can* reduce you below 0.
- If you reach **negative half your Max HP (rounded up)**, you die.

You are on the ground. That is literal, and it stays true until you spend an action getting up.

While Down

You are Down from the moment you Collapse until you stand. Healing above 0 HP ends the Collapse — it does not stand you up.

Down is not unconscious. You are on the ground and finished as an attacker, but you are awake, aware, and still covering yourself.

- You cannot attack.
- You cannot change position.
- **You defend normally.** Choose a card face down and resolve the exchange exactly as a standing combatant would, Defense Effect and all. Attack Resolution runs against you in full — including the attacker's Blind check — so an attack on a Down character can still miss.
- **You keep your one free action each turn** (Free Actions, above). Eating, drinking, and activating your own gear all work from the ground. Moving does not: a banked Quick has no Move Position to spend itself on while you're Down, so it simply holds.
- Your Action is unavailable while you're Down, with one exception — standing up, once you have the HP for it (Standing Up, below).
- You may be healed back into combat.
- Every **3 in-game hours** spent Collapsed, recover **1d4 HP**.

Standing Up

Once you are above 0 HP, **standing costs your action** on your turn. You are Down until you spend it, and you act normally from your next turn onward.

A revived ally is not immediately back on offense. They were covering themselves the whole time they were down, but they are still on the ground and one turn away from being useful — which is the real cost of going down, and the reason healing someone before they Collapse is worth more than healing them after.

If the Entire Party Collapses

The enemy determines the outcome based on their intent, nature, and what the fiction demands. Death is possible — but it is not automatic. Captivity, humiliation, forced retreat, and stranger fates are all on the table.

The world does not guarantee fairness. It only guarantees consequence.

GM Override

The GM may declare instant death at any point if the fiction demands it — a beheading, a fall into the void, a creature that does not leave survivors. The collapse rules exist to create dramatic space, not to protect players from a world that can genuinely kill them. Use this power with intention, not frequency.

Resolution

Core Resolution

When a character attempts something risky outside of combat, roll:

2d10 + relevant stat

Compare the result to a Difficulty Class set by the GM.

DIFFICULTY	DC
Easy	11
Normal	13
Hard	16
Extreme	19

Meet or beat the DC to succeed.

The fiction determines which stat applies — Body for physical exertion, Mind for reasoning and interpretation, Soul for bonds, will, and spiritual pressure. When multiple stats could apply, the player may make their case. The GM decides.

Advantage & Disadvantage

If a card in your hand has a name that meaningfully supports what you're attempting, you may discard it to gain **Advantage**.

- **Advantage** — Roll 3d10, discard the lowest.
- **Disadvantage** — Roll 3d10, discard the highest.

*Note: Advantage and Disadvantage on skill checks and saves use the 3d10 system above — a separate mechanic from combat. The combat-damage versions are named **Deadly** and **Weak** specifically so neither collides with the skill-check terms here — but they don't work the same way as the roll above. Deadly adds a d6 to the next damage roll; Weak subtracts one; a held stack of each cancels 1-for-1 on consumption. See [rules/card-glossary.md](#) for the actual rule.*

The table must agree the card meaningfully supports the action. When in doubt, ask: *would a reasonable person look at this card name and understand the connection?*

A Passive grants Advantage the same way — the table judges whether its printed name plausibly supports the attempt, exactly as it would a discarded card's name. Unlike a discarded card, a Passive is never spent; it can support the same kind of attempt again next time.

Neither one stacks. However many sources apply to one roll — a Passive, a discarded card, both at once — the result is still just Advantage: roll 3d10, drop the lowest. It never compounds into anything bigger. Disadvantage works the same way in the other direction.

Advantage and Disadvantage cancel. If both apply to the same roll, they cancel and you roll a flat 2d10 + stat. Because neither side stacks, this is all-or-nothing rather than one-for-one: any amount of Advantage against any amount of Disadvantage leaves a plain roll.

Checks

Checks are active attempts — you're trying to do something.

- **Body Check** — Overcome a physical obstacle or impose physical control.
 - **Mind Check** — Obtain or interpret information, solve, predict, or argue.
 - **Soul Check** — Create or maintain bonds, resist spiritual pressure, enforce oaths.
-

Saves

Saves are reactive — something is happening to you.

- **Body Save** — Fatigue, falls, cold, pain, forced movement.
- **Mind Save** — Illusions, manipulation, memory interference.
- **Soul Save** — Fear, corruption, possession, despair, spiritual confusion.

The difference matters: a character who fails a **check** didn't accomplish what they set out to do. A character who fails a **save** suffers a consequence they couldn't fully prevent.

Skills

A roll a Skill plainly covers gets +2, flat, added to the 2d10 + stat. **This applies to Checks and Saves alike** — what you're trained in helps you whether you went looking for the situation or it came looking for you. The table judges "plainly covers" the same way it judges whether a discarded card's name supports Advantage, above — except a Skill is an exact tag, not a name, so there's usually nothing to argue about.

Stacks with Advantage. A Skill's +2 and an Advantage swap (from a Passive or a discarded card) are different currencies — nothing stops both applying to the same roll.

What a Skill actually is, and how many you have: `rules/character-creation.md`, Skills.

Perception

Perception is not a single roll. When a character tries to notice something, the GM determines what kind of signal is present and assigns the appropriate mode. The player may propose a different mode if the fiction supports it.

Reason (Mind) — Pattern & Detail

You notice information that must be interpreted.

Use for: Hidden mechanisms, symbols, inconsistencies, tracking, investigation, puzzle clues, reading tactics or routines, environmental details that "don't add up."

Failure usually means: You miss the meaning, not the presence. You may draw false conclusions.

Senses (Body) — Timing & Physical Signal

You notice signals the body reacts to faster than thought.

Use for: Hearing movement, feeling vibrations, reacting to sudden danger, navigating unstable ground or darkness, detecting ambushes, shifts in balance, pressure, or temperature.

Failure usually means: You react too late. You're off-balance or out of position.

Read (Soul) — Intent & Weight

You notice what is emotionally, socially, or spiritually present.

Use for: Reading lies, fear, or confidence; sensing curses, blessings, corruption; judging whether a promise or threat is real; detecting hostile tension; places or people that "feel wrong."

Failure usually means: You misjudge sincerity. You're emotionally or spiritually misled.

The One Table Rule

When a player says *"I look around"* or *"I try to get a read on this,"* ask one question: **What are you trying to notice?**

- *What it is* → **Reason (Mind)**
- *When or where it happens* → **Senses (Body)**
- *What it intends or signifies* → **Read (Soul)**

This keeps perception active and specific. Vague sensing gets vague results. A player who names what they're looking for — and is right about which mode applies — gets a sharper answer on success.

Resting

Short Rest

Duration: 20 minutes **Limit:** 3 per day **Effect:** Recover **2d6 + Body** HP

Short rests can be chained — three back-to-back is an hour of recovery. The daily limit resets on a long rest.

Long Rest

Duration: 7½ hours **Effect:** Full heal

A long rest requires genuine safety and uninterrupted time. The GM determines whether current circumstances allow one. In most regions of Eclipseria, they often don't.

Cards

Cards are the primary language of Tales Untold.

In combat, you don't declare an action and roll — you play a card. The card tells you what you're attempting, how hard it hits, and what happens when it lands or fails. Your hand is your tactical options. Your deck is your character in motion.

What each field on a card means, "Attacker"/"Defender" vs. "Target," and a full worked example: `rules/combat.md`, Reading a Card.

The Die Is the Card's Personality

When you look at a hand of cards, the dice tell you who you are right now.

A hand full of d8s is a brawler who hits hard and moves with purpose. A d10 is a fourth tier and a Red one — three cards in the game carry it, and each pays for it somewhere else on its own text. A hand full of d4s is a strategist watching for the moment everything opens up. A hand full of d6s is someone threading the gap between the two.

Your deck is not just mechanics. It's how your character thinks.

What Each Colour Tends Toward

General conventions, not laws. A card that breaks one for a good reason is fine; a colour that breaks its own convention constantly has stopped meaning anything.

- **Red — self-buffs and raw damage.** The biggest dice live here.
- **Blue — enemy control.** Debuffs, repositioning them, taking their options away.
- **Green — flexibility and support.** Healing, allies, movement, adaptability.

Why Red has the biggest dice — range pays for them

The die is bought with range, and each colour spends its range budget differently. That is the whole of it, and it means the damage spread between colours is a *consequence* of their range identity rather than a thumb on the scale for Red.

- **Red is the most restricted**, so it is paid the most.
- **Blue sits in the middle** — Ranged is a real restriction, but a softer one than Melee.
- **Green is the most flexible**, so it is paid the least. Both-range is the default, and the default die is small.

Measured across the 164 core cards, 2026-09-19:

COLOUR	MELEE	RANGED	BOTH	MEAN DIE
Red	53%	17%	30%	6.27
Blue	28%	60%	12%	5.36
Green	15%	30%	56%	5.04

And restriction really is the driver, not colour. Ignore colour entirely and sort the same cards by range alone: **Melee d6.44, Ranged d5.39, Both d4.93.** The ordering is the same one, and it holds *inside* each colour as well — Red runs d7.00 Melee against d5.11 Both, Blue d5.57 against d4.33, Green d5.75 against d4.93.

What this is for. It tells you what a new card should cost before you argue about it: a Both-range card wants a small die whatever colour it is, and a Melee card has already paid for a big one. It also tells a player something real at character creation — **a Mind- or Soul-primary character drafts from a smaller-dice pool than a Body-primary one**, by roughly half a point of expected damage per card, and is being paid for it in reach and flexibility rather than shortchanged.

Red Melee runs a full die step above Blue Melee and Green Melee — 7.00 against 5.57 and 5.75 — and that part is deliberate rather than drift. **Each colour's stat is paid in a different currency**, and Red's is damage: Body buys the damage *and* the HP, Mind buys hand size, Soul buys initiative. Red buys a little more with range than the other two because damage is the thing Red is for.

*That premium was set when Body was a $\times 3$ multiplier on HP rather than $\times 4$, so it is fair to ask whether the damage gap should have closed when the HP weight went up. **It was measured on 2026-09-19 and the answer is no.** With Passives in play the three colours finish within 1.4 points of each other over 750 duels — the economy is already balanced, the $\times 3 \rightarrow \times 4$ change moved the colours under two points against each other, and softening Red's dice moves nothing at all.*
combat-simulations/README.md, What Passives are actually for.

Some keywords scale by colour rather than by die and range. Thorns is the clearest: it is retaliation damage, so it belongs to Body, and the number is set by the card's colour — **Green 2, Blue 3, Red 4** — regardless of die or range. This is a game-wide rule, not a core-set one: creature signature cards follow the same ladder.

Two cards sit off that on purpose. **BRISTLE** is Green at 3: both its halves do nothing but grant Thorns, and it is Melee-only, so it buys the extra point with the range restriction and with having no second effect — **CONFRONT**, the other Green melee Thorns card, sits at the base 2 because it spends its defence half on Counter Attack instead. **PAIN IS FUEL** is Red at 2: it re-grants every turn you hold Anchored, and Thorns stacks additively, so a flat 4 there would be a different card.

The ladder is retired as of 2026-09-17. Drew called it that morning: a rule described as game-wide, already carrying two named exceptions out of the handful of cards using it, is on its way to not being a rule. By the end of the day it had failed in both directions.

COLOUR	LADDER SAID	WHAT THE CARDS ACTUALLY DO
Green	2	CONFRONT 2 — and BRISTLE at 3
Blue	3	nothing. RETORT was Blue's only Thorns card, and it dropped Thorns entirely

COLOUR	LADDER SAID	WHAT THE CARDS ACTUALLY DO
Red	4	RETALIATE 4, SHATTER 3, PAIN IS FUEL 2

Red was the colour the ladder anchored and it holds three different values across three cards. Blue has none at all, and BRAMBLE — the card that existed to be Green's rung and did nothing else — was cut on 2026-09-18 once the ladder stopped justifying it — which is the outcome the colour conventions above should have predicted from the start: **Thorns is retaliation damage, so it belongs to Body, and Blue was only ever holding it because a ladder said every colour needed a rung.** Price Thorns per card, on the die and the range, the way everything else is priced.

BRISTLE at 3 was once a strict dominance against RETORT, which read "Gain Thorns 3" at a smaller die and a freer range. RETORT's defence half became Weak on 2026-09-08, and on 2026-09-17 its attack half dropped Thorns for Vulnerable — the card does what Blue does now, taking an enemy's options away rather than mirroring a Green card in another colour. That is the lesson worth keeping: two cards can share a keyword and a number as long as they aren't the same card, and a card that has to be argued into its colour probably belongs in a different one.

The crossovers are deliberate and worth keeping: Red still body-blocks for the party, Blue still helps allies, Green can still focus damage down. A colour with no exceptions is a colour nobody has to think about.

Effect strength is paid for in the die, and in Range. Where the same effect appears in more than one colour, the pool prices it: OPEN GUARD, MARKED, and OPENING all apply Vulnerable, at d8/Melee, d6/Ranged, and d4/Both. UNBROKEN, LAST RESORT, and UNTOUCHED are the same trade on Immunity. Read those ladders before setting a new card's die — the pool has already decided what that effect costs.

The Attack line can carry more than the die. Most cards read **Body + d8** and stop there, but the line legitimately holds anything that changes the roll or is paid to make it: a conditional bonus die (RHYTHM BREAK's **+1d6** against someone who moved, TRACE's **+2d6**, UNDERSTANDING's discard-for- **+1d6**), a doubled attack (TWIN STRIKE's **(Soul + d4) × 2**), or an HP cost (REPAY's **Pay 3 HP**). OVERCOMMIT puts a whole status there — **Gain Vulnerable** — which stretches the convention furthest.

This matters when reviewing: a card's power is not readable from its Effect lines alone, and a summary that lists only die, range and effects will show TWIN STRIKE as a plain d4 and RHYTHM BREAK as a d8 with nothing on offence. Both readings are wrong. Read the Attack line.

The Oracle Deck

The starting Oracle deck is where a player learns what the game is, so it is deliberately narrower than the card pool it draws from. **Nothing in it reaches into an enemy's hand, deck, or stats directly.** Specifically, no Oracle card may:

- reveal or look at an enemy's hand
- force an enemy to discard
- insert status cards into an enemy's hand, deck, or discard
- manipulate an enemy's deck
- reduce an enemy's stats

- apply Sealed
- cost an enemy a whole attack or a whole defence, however it is worded, with one exception (below)

Losing a whole attack or a whole defence is the one near-total ban, and it is written against the effect, not the keyword. That swing is bigger than anything else on this list and not something a starting deck should hand out four times over. Red keeps exactly one card that reaches it — OFF BALANCE, which applies Staggered on a clean win only, so it has to be earned rather than traded for.

Initiative Shift is not this, and the difference is the whole reason it is a separate mechanic. A negative shift puts more people in front of you; it does not take your turn away. The turn still arrives, later, and everyone can see exactly when by looking at the wheel. Staggered deletes an instance outright, silently, and there is nothing to read off the table about when it stops mattering. So a card that pushes an enemy back in the order is board control like positioning or targeting, and belongs in a starting deck; a card that costs them the attack itself does not. Carved out deliberately on 2026-09-18 — RETALIATE, DOUBLE DOWN and INTERRUPT are all seated and all push the attacker back, and reading the ban to cover them would have cut three cards for doing the thing initiative is for.

Staggered is the usual wording, and it is not the only one. "Cannot defend until your next turn," "the attacker cannot defend next time you attack them," "skip your next attack" — all of it lands in the same place and all of it is barred. This was written against the keyword until 2026-09-17, and ABANDON sat in the gap for eleven days doing exactly what Staggered does with the word left off (`experimental/archives/cut-cards.md`). When you are checking a card against this rule, ask what the target loses, not which word the card used.

Acting on **your own** hand and deck is fine — drawing, discarding to pay a cost, Scry on your own deck. So is control that operates on the board rather than on someone's resources: statuses, positioning, initiative, targeting restrictions, removing buffs an enemy already has. The line is between changing the situation and going through their possessions.

Exiling an enemy's card is deck manipulation, not board control. This one is easy to seat by mistake, and was: a card they have played looks like it is already spent, but it is on its way to their discard, and their discard reshuffles into their deck. Exiling it shrinks what they draw from for the rest of the fight. FORGET and FRACTURE both do this and both are barred — FORGET was seated in the expansion for nine days before anyone caught it, and the rewrite that was supposed to make it legal only copied the illegal half onto the other side.

Cards excluded by this rule are still perfectly good cards; they belong in creature decks, character decks, and later Oracle additions. The list lives in `printing/generate-cards.py`'s `SETS`, with the same rule restated above it.

Legal is not the same as early. This rule bars what a starting deck may never do; it does not settle whether a legal card is right for players still learning the reveal. The cards cleared for a first campaign, the screen they were cleared against, and the ones that failed it are in `rules/early-campaign-cards.md`.

The deck comes in two sets, 63 cards then 21. The original prints as `oracle`; the expansion prints separately as `oracle-expansion`, so a review pass over the newer cards doesn't mean re-reading the older ones. They are one deck — the split is for reading, not for play. The expansion holds each colour's range identity at the same ratio (4/2/1 against the first set's 12/6/3), and the content rule above applies to both without exception.

The Name Is Half the Card

A card's name carries as much weight as its Effect line, because the name is what a player spends outside combat. Discarding a card for Advantage asks the table whether its *name* plausibly supports what you're attempting (`rules/resolution.md`, Advantage & Disadvantage) — so a name is a promise about the kinds of noncombat problems that card can help solve.

Two consequences when writing or reworking a card:

- **A broad name is a stronger card**, whatever its Effect line says, because it applies to more attempts. FOCUS supports nearly anything requiring concentration; CARD TRICK supports card tricks. Breadth is real power, so weigh it the way you weigh a die size — a wide name on top of a strong Effect is a card that does two jobs. That cuts the other way too: a deliberately narrow name is a fair place to pay for an unusually good Effect.
- **Renaming a card changes what it can do out of combat**, not just how it reads. Check that the new name still covers the same ground, and that nothing else already holds it — duplicate names break the print pipeline's by-name lookups, which is exactly how the Red and Green BRACE collided (`experimental/archives/cut-cards.md`).

A working vocabulary to name from, sorted by colour and by mechanic, with names already used by a card struck out of it: `experimental/card-name-verbs.md`.

Card Glossary

Short versions for reading cards. `rules/card-glossary.md` is canonical for keywords like the one below; `rules/combat.md` is canonical for Range and Ongoing Effects.

Scry X — Look at the top X cards of a deck (your own unless the card targets another). Place each on top, on the bottom, or into the discard pile, in any order.

Deck Building

Deck size is total stats, for everyone. Body + Mind + Soul, player and creature alike — 9 for a starting character, and it moves only when a stat does. A player's cards past that maximum sit in their card bank and swap in at advancement (`rules/character-creation.md`, Advancement); a creature simply never has more than its stats allow.

Player decks — the stat-matching heuristic. A solid default: the number of cards of each color matches the corresponding stat. Mind 4 / Body 2 / Soul 3 → 4 Blue, 2 Red, 3 Green. The deck's color weight mirrors who the character is — and since damage runs off the matching stat, it keeps every card in the deck pulling at full strength. A heuristic, not a law: drafting through the Oracle (see `rules/character-creation.md`, Advancement) can and should bend it.

Trading cards. Cards change hands at the Underground Bazaar and effectively nowhere else (`places/capital/underground-bazaar.md`, The Card Economy). Selling is always possible and permanent; buying is rare, is paid for in cards, memories, or secrets rather than coin, and adds to what you hold rather than swapping into the deck — at the size cap that means the bought card lands in the bank until an advancement makes room for it. Everywhere else in the world a card is earned — from the Oracle, or from whatever taught it.

Signature cards follow the core set's conventions. They are written for one stat block, but they are the same object as a core card and are read by the same players: same fields, same keyword vocabulary (numbered where the glossary numbers it), same Thorns ladder, and the same treatment of Range as a real cost. Range especially — a creature whose cards are all Both is a creature that never has to think about position, in a game that spends a third of the Oracle's design space teaching it. Signature cards ran 51% Both until 2026-09-09; they now sit at roughly a third each, leaning Melee because most things that attack you have to reach you first.

Enemy decks. Deck size equals the creature's **total stats** — the same number the player rule caps at, except a creature has no bank and no advancement, so its deck is simply built to that size once and stays there (a few bosses are deliberately built under it; `bestiary/hullback.md` and `bestiary/fermata.md` say so on their own entries) — with each color's count equal to the matching stat (signature cards count toward their color). Build 3 themed signature cards, then fill from the core lists (`cards/red-body.md` , `cards/blue-mind.md` , `cards/green-soul.md`) to reach the stat counts, leaning picks toward the creature's temperament. Enemies draw to hand size (Mind, minimum 2) like everyone else.

"Allies"/"enemies" in card text never include yourself: `rules/combat.md` , You Are Not Your Own Ally.

Card Keyword Glossary

Canonical definitions for all keywords and status cards used in Tales Untold. When a card uses a keyword, this is the ruling. Card text that contradicts this file should be treated as an error.

Special Rule — some cards carry a Special Rule line instead of, or alongside, an Effect and a Defense Effect. It overrides normal resolution exactly as printed on that card.

Keywords

At the table — status-effect tokens. A card that grants a temporary status — a Debuff or a Positive Status Effect, landing on you, an ally, or a foe — doesn't need a separate physical token. The card *is* the token: set it face-up in front of whoever it's affecting instead of sending it straight to the discard pile, and discard it for real once the effect resolves, triggers, or expires. Same physical technique Ongoing Effects already use (`rules/combat.md`). Not just a bookkeeping convenience: the card is out of its owner's rotation the whole time it's serving as a token — it isn't in their discard pile, so it isn't coming back on a reshuffle either. That's a real cost on whoever cast it, whether the card debuffed a foe or buffed an ally.

Counter Attack Deal this card's Attack damage back to the attacker, works with effects like deadly.

Debuff Weak, Blind, Vulnerable, Staggered, Rooted, and stat reductions — the six effects Ward can prevent.

Positive Status Effects Evade, Resist, Deadly, Protect, Anchored, Quick, and Immunity. A card that references this term by name (rather than listing them out) means all of these at once.

Deadly The next time you roll attack damage, add an additional d6 to the result. Stacks: each stack applies to one future damage roll, not extra dice on the same roll. 1 stack of Deadly and 1 stack of Weak held at the same time cancel each other out.

Weak The next time you roll attack damage, subtract an additional d6 from the result. Stacks the same way Deadly does: each stack applies to one future damage roll, not extra dice on the same roll. Cancels 1-for-1 with Deadly (above).

Anchored A specific benefit persists as long as you do not change positions, triggering at the start of each of your turns. The card states who it targets — not always yourself: PATIENCE OF STONE heals its own caster, ROOTED OATH buffs a named ally, GRAPPLE holds the defender Rooted. Anchored is about what holding position sustains, not about who it's aimed at. If you move — voluntarily or by an enemy effect — Anchored ends immediately. It also ends immediately if you Collapse.

Anchored is worth less than it looks, and it should be priced as a discount on an effect rather than a tax on one. It does not pay on the turn you play it — the first trigger is the start of your *next* turn. Two triggers is roughly what one plain grant of the same effect is worth; three is where it starts being a good deal, and three triggers means the fight has already run four turns or more.

The cost that gets missed is your own movement, not the enemy's. Forced movement breaking Anchored is obvious. The quieter one: sit in the Backline playing Ranged and Both cards for a couple of turns and the Melee cards pile up in hand as dead weight — a Melee card can't even be played as a defence unless both combatants are Frontline. Getting any value out of them means moving, which ends the Anchored. Holding position instead means playing around a shrinking set of live options, and if you're leaning on passive cards to stay put, you aren't gaining an extra effect during the turns you're holding either.

Written down because Anchored reads stronger than it plays, and reviewers keep arriving at "this needs a restriction." It already has three: the delay, the movement, and the hand it strands.

Blind 50% chance to miss whatever you're doing in the exchange — attacking or defending, not attacker-only. Checked once both sides have already committed a card face down, before the reveal (`rules/combat.md` , Attack Resolution): roll 1d2, and on a 1, whoever holds it misses. The check always happens if it applies, even when another check in the same exchange already decided the outcome — see the resolution order in `rules/combat.md` .

An attacker's miss alone ends the exchange in the defender's favor — the defender auto-wins the resolution, exactly as if the RPS reveal had gone their way, and the attacker's card is discarded. **A defender's miss alone** on their own block resolves exactly like having no legal defense: the attacker wins automatically. **Both missing in the same exchange** is neither of those — it's a Mutual Miss (`rules/combat.md` , Attack Resolution): the attack failed and the attempted block against it also failed, so nobody wins and no Effect or Defense Effect triggers. A defender's Evade succeeding overrides all of this — a clean dodge wins the exchange outright regardless of what either Blind roll says.

Lasts until the end of your next turn unless the card specifies otherwise. Blind and Evade are separate checks, and a single exchange rolls every one that applies.

Evade 50% chance to dodge an attack declared against you. Checked after you've chosen your defense (or declined to defend), before either card is revealed (`rules/combat.md` , Attack Resolution) — triggered by being attacked, not by whether the attack would actually land, so it rolls (and a stack is spent) even when the attacker already missed to their own Blind. Roll 1d2 — on a 1, you auto-win the resolution exactly as if the RPS reveal had gone your way: the attacker's card is discarded and its own Effect does not trigger.

Evade stacks. Each stack protects against one attack. Only one Evade triggers per attack — you cannot roll multiple times against the same attack.

Cover Evade is not this keyword. Taking cover grants a dodge that rolls the same way but persists instead of being spent, and it takes the place of your stacks while it lasts rather than adding to them (`rules/combat.md` , Positioning → Cover).

Exile Remove a card from play for the rest of combat. It does not go to the discard pile and cannot be retrieved. When combat ends, exiled cards return to their owner's discard.

A status card that is exiled is destroyed instead — it never comes back. Exile is the one way to answer a Wound, an Exhaust, or a curse permanently in the middle of a fight.

Protect The next time an ally would take attack damage, you take it instead.

Initiative Shift X A positive shift moves the target's token X positions counterclockwise around the wheel (see `rules/combat.md`); a negative shift moves it X positions clockwise.

Sooner and later are measured against when that token's own next turn would have arrived — not by where it ends up sitting in the ring. Going last is not the same as acting later: a token that has already acted this lap sits exactly where a token that has already acted sits, and waiting a full lap from there is the ordinary cost of having gone.

Onto the marker's slot is not across it. A positive shift that lands exactly on the marker's own slot simply lands there — the token moves, everything it passed slides, and no chip is placed. Only a shift with **further to travel than the distance to the marker** has actually crossed, and crossing is what earns the extra turn below.

Initiative Shift always moves the token the full requested distance. Where a shift would run past the end of what the wheel can express, place a chip instead of changing the movement.

Tracking skips and bonus turns. Place a skip chip on a token that needs to be skipped; when the marker reaches it, skip its turn and remove the chip. Place a bonus chip on a token that's earned an immediate extra turn instead; take that turn, then remove the chip.

Multiple shifts applied to the same token at once sum into one net shift before it applies. **A combatant shifting itself on its own turn is the exception, and it is not a small one.** They are standing on the marker's slot, so the distance to it is zero and every positive shift would read as a crossing — QUICKEN would be a free extra turn, every time. It is not: nothing carries you past a point you are standing on. Measure it the way this section says to, against when their own next turn would have arrived. Having just acted, that is after everyone else; a shift of X makes it X sooner than that, down to a floor of acting next. No chip, no skip. The mirror case is the one that reads backwards if you are not careful. A combatant on the marker's slot is at position 0, but their **next** turn is a full table away — they have just acted, so everyone else goes before they come round again. Read their slot as their place in the queue and every shift on them comes out inverted.

So measure from where their next turn actually was. **A negative shift of X puts X more turns in front of theirs,** whoever cast it. At a table of four, where a turn normally comes round after three others: -1 is after four, -2 after five, -3 after six. The ring says it in two parts — the token sits X slots along and is passed over once when the marker first reaches it — but what a player needs to know is the first sentence. One more person goes before you for each point.

It is a later turn, not a lost one, which is what keeps this clear of the Oracle content rule's ban on costing an enemy a whole attack (`rules/cards.md`). The turn arrives, and the wheel shows exactly when.

At the table this is two motions and they are easy to do by hand: slide the token along, and pass it over the first time the marker reaches it. A big delay at a small table passes it over more than once — at a table of three, a -3 is skipped the first time it comes round and acts again after five others. Every delay is reachable at every table size; there is no case the ring cannot say.

For everyone else, the crossing rule stands. If a positive shift's distance is **greater than the distance to the marker's own slot** — so the token would be carried past the point where it must act now — the target instead receives an immediate extra turn, taken as soon as the currently-resolving turn finishes. The combatant already acting when this happens is not shorted a turn, but doesn't get a second one either: the slide moves them to a new slot, and the marker skips that slot when it reaches it, since they already acted this lap. That skip is specifically compensation for the bonus turn just granted — an ordinary bystander displaced by sliding, with no bonus turn triggering it, simply acts normally when the marker reaches wherever it landed. A negative shift is the mirror case: if its math would let the target act sooner than the marker's normal progression allows, the shift still moves the target's token and slides the wheel in full, but the target's turn is skipped the first time the marker reaches its new slot — it acts normally starting the next lap. Reshifting a

token that already carries a pending skip or bonus chip removes the pending chip — the token then resolves normally under the new shift, whatever slot it lands on.

For worked cases covering all of the above, see `rules/initiative-shift-examples.md`.

Lifesteal Heal for half the damage this attack actually dealt to HP, rounded down — after Resist and any other reduction, since that's the amount that landed.

Resist The next time an enemy successfully attacks you, take half damage rounded down. Expires after the next successful attack against you.

Resist stacks. Each stack halves one successful attack; only one stack applies to a given attack. "Resist X" grants X stacks. 1 stack of Resist and 1 stack of Vulnerable (below) held at the same time cancel each other out, checked before either applies.

Armour X Reduce all incoming attack damage by X. It applies to every attack, for the whole fight — it is not consumed and does not expire.

Armour applies **before** Resist and Vulnerable, so a creature with both takes the flat reduction first and the halving second. Unpreventable damage ignores Armour entirely, the same way it ignores every other attack-damage defense. An attack reduced to 0 still landed: the attacker's Effect resolves normally, it simply has no damage to work with.

Armour stacks additively into a single value. Armour 2 and Armour 1 held at once are Armour 3, reducing every attack by 3 for the rest of the fight. This is a different shape of stacking from Resist and Vulnerable: those stack as charges, each spent on one attack. Armour is never spent, so its stacks add up instead of queuing up.

Armour is the system's general-purpose flat damage reduction: it shows up as a creature passive, as the Armor equipment tier's own effect, and on consumables. Anything that says "reduce damage by X" is Armour X.

Vulnerable The next time an enemy successfully attacks you, take 50% more damage, rounded down. Expires after the next successful attack against you — same shape as Resist, opposite direction. A Debuff, removable by Ward. Stacks the same way Resist does: each stack applies to one future successful attack, not a running multiplier. Cancels 1-for-1 with Resist (above) rather than ever applying alongside it.

Rooted The next time you would change position, that movement is cancelled and the Rooted is spent. It is a charge, not a timer — it waits as long as it has to, and it is used up by the first movement it stops, whenever that comes.

It stops forced movement too, and is spent doing it. A Pull, a compelled Rushdown, a card that shoves you to the other position — Rooted cancels that just as it cancels your own Move Position, and then it is gone. This is the trade: Rooted is harder to wait out than a timer, and an enemy can strip it by making you move.

Rooted stacks. Each stack cancels one movement.

Anchored + Rooted. When an Anchored effect re-applies Rooted to a fixed original target (GRAPPLE — see Anchored, above), that target gains a fresh Rooted charge at the start of each of your turns for as long as you remain Anchored. Moving ends your own Anchored and stops further re-application; it does not spend a Rooted charge the target is already holding.

Card text. A card that grants Rooted should say only "gains Rooted" — the rule lives here, not restated on the card.

Quick A banked free Move Position, Rushdown included — spending it is your one free action for the turn (`rules/combat.md` , Turn Structure) and costs nothing from your Action. Holds until spent, however many turns that takes. Stacks: hold as many as you've been granted, spend one per turn.

Scry X Look at the top X cards of a deck. If no target is specified, this applies to your own deck. For each card, choose to place it on top, on the bottom, or into the discard pile — in any order.

Staggered The next time you would attack or defend, that one instance is skipped instead — either you skip attacking on your turn, or an incoming attack goes undefended — whichever comes first. Staggered ends the instant that happens.

Thorns X Deal X damage to any enemy that successfully hits you with a melee attack. Applies after the attack resolves. Persists until end of combat unless the card states otherwise.

Thorns stacks additively into a single value, the same way Armour does — Thorns 2 and Thorns 1 held at once are Thorns 3, dealt to every melee attacker for the rest of the fight. Not consumed, so stacks add rather than queue.

Unpreventable Damage that cannot be defended against. It ignores every defense that applies to attack damage — Armour, Resist, and reassignment (Protect) — because those defend only against attacks. Thorns, status damage, and HP costs are unpreventable: they land on their target in full and cannot be reduced, reassigned, or capped.

Ward Prevent the next Debuff (above) applied to you. Triggers automatically the instant a qualifying Debuff would apply — no declaration required. Expires on use.

Immunity The next attack damage you would take is reduced to 0. Nothing else about the exchange changes: cards are chosen and revealed as normal, the RPS outcome stands, and the attacker's Effect and any Defense Effect trigger exactly as they otherwise would. Only the damage is negated.

It applies inside the Damage Pipeline (`rules/combat.md`), which has two consequences worth knowing. It protects whoever actually receives the damage, so an attack reassigned onto someone else meets *their* Immunity, not yours. And it does nothing against unpreventable damage — Thorns, status damage, and HP costs were never attack damage to begin with.

One use, spent the moment it actually negates something. An exchange that deals you no damage anyway — you won, or it was a tie — leaves it untouched for the next one.

Stat Change

Not a keyword — a shared mechanic. Some cards change one of your stats for a combat (Sunder drains Mind, Wither drains Body, Erode drains Soul; other cards may raise a stat). A changed stat uses its new value for everything it governs, in real time:

- **Body** — Red-card damage, and max HP at **4 points per point of Body** (down when lost, up when gained) — the heaviest of the three shares by a wide margin, matching the HP formula's own weighting: $(4 \times \text{Body}) + \text{Soul} + \text{Mind}$.
- **Mind** — Blue-card damage; hand size (equal to Mind, minimum 2 — hand size never drops below 2, however far Mind falls; changes the moment the stat does, and a hand already above the new, lower size is not discarded down, it simply can't draw back up until it naturally falls below the cap); and max HP at **1 point per point of Mind**.

- **Soul** — Green-card damage; initiative (1d6 + Soul, applied to rolls made after the change); and max HP at **1 point per point of Soul**.

All three stats touch max HP (*changed 2026-08-06 to match the HP formula's own three-stat shape — Body at 4×, Mind and Soul at 1× each; previously Body was the only stat that did. Body's multiplier went from 3× to 4× on 2026-09-06, widening the HP spread so Body carries more of it.*). If a loss puts your current HP above the new maximum, current HP falls to the maximum; if your maximum reaches 0 you Collapse. Increasing max HP does not increase current HP.

A stat change lasts for the combat unless a card says otherwise, then the stat — and any max HP, hand size, or initiative it moved — returns to normal. This applies to every current and future stat-changing card; the card only states the stat and amount.

Status Cards

Status cards are placed into decks as consequences. They cannot be played. They must be managed.

WOUND Status — *Colorless* Cannot be played. It stays in your hand and occupies a card slot — a Wound does not leave on its own. In combat, use your action to destroy 1 Wound from your hand. Once per short rest, destroy 1 Wound from your hand, discard pile, or deck. Short rests chain (`rules/resting.md`), so clearing several Wounds in one sitting costs time, not repetition. On a long rest, all Wounds are destroyed.

EXHAUST Status — *Colorless* Cannot be played. It occupies a card slot while in your hand, and an Exhaust does not leave on its own. Where it enters is whatever the source card says — hand or deck. A card that adds Exhaust to your hand costs you the slot immediately; a card that shuffles Exhaust into your deck costs you nothing until you draw it. Use your action to rest in place: every Exhaust card in your hand is destroyed. A short or long rest removes every copy of Exhaust from your hand, deck, and discard pile.

Exhaust always clears in bulk; a Wound comes off one at a time. That is the difference between them. Rest once and every Exhaust you are carrying is gone at once, wherever it sits. Wounds have to be answered individually — one per action, one per short rest.

The Wheel & Initiative Shift — Worked Examples

Compact worked cases for the Wheel and Initiative Shift, in a short notation: four combatants, **a** through **d**, listed clockwise starting from whoever's currently acting. Read the Wheel (`rules/combat.md`) and Initiative Shift X (`rules/card-glossary.md`) first — this file exists to make those rules concrete, not to restate them.

Example 1 — An ordinary shift

a, b, c, d. a is acting. a plays a card with Initiative Shift +1 targeting c.

c moves 1 slot counterclockwise, toward the marker. It passes through b's slot on the way, so b slides 1 slot toward the gap c left behind.

Result: a, c, b, d. No boundary hit, no chip needed. a's turn ends normally; c goes next, then b, then d.

Demonstrates the base case — most Initiative Shift plays are exactly this. Sliding always happens; skip and bonus chips are only for the wraparound cases below.

Example 2 — A negative shift that overshoots

a, b, c, d. a plays Initiative Shift -2 on d.

d's clockwise math wraps past a full lap and would land it *sooner* than its own start — this is the boundary Initiative Shift's negative-shift guarantee exists to catch. The shift and the slide both still happen in full: **a, b, c, d** becomes **b, d, c, a**, with a **skip chip** placed on d.

Turn sequence this lap: a's turn ends → b goes next → **d is skipped** (chip removed) → c goes → a goes again (a was slid to a not-yet-visited slot this lap; nothing protects a bystander from acting twice when that happens — see Example 4). Next lap, the new order (**b, d, c, a**) runs normally with no chips pending.

Demonstrates the ordinary skip case, and that a displaced bystander with no bonus turn to compensate for just acts on schedule wherever it lands.

Example 3 — A positive shift landing exactly on the marker's slot

a, b, c, d. a is acting. a plays Initiative Shift +3 on d.

d sits 3 slots from the marker and the shift is 3, so it lands **exactly** on the marker's own slot. **Onto is not across.** The shift and slide happen in full: **a, b, c, d** becomes **d, a, b, c**, and **no chip is placed on anyone.**

Turn sequence this lap: a's turn ends → **d goes next** → a goes → b goes → c goes. Then the new order (d, a, b, c) runs normally.

Why d goes next rather than last: the marker belongs to a *slot*, not to a combatant, and it has not finished with its own slot — d slid into it. So d takes the very next turn. **Nobody is skipped and nobody gets an extra turn;** d simply cut to the front of the line, which is what a positive shift is supposed to do.

Demonstrates the boundary that isn't one. Landing on the marker's slot is a landing, not a crossing — d moved as far toward acting sooner as the wheel can express, and it cost nobody a turn. Compare Example 3b, where the shift has further to travel than the distance to the marker, genuinely crosses it, and does cost somebody a turn.

Example 3b — A positive shift that actually crosses the marker

a, b, c, d. a is acting. a plays Initiative Shift +2 on b.

b sits 1 slot from the marker and the shift is 2 — further to travel than the distance to the marker, so b crosses it. There is no slot past "now": b takes an **immediate extra turn** instead. a, b, c, d becomes **b, a, c, d**, with a **bonus chip** on b and a **skip chip** on a — the combatant displaced off the marker's own slot, in compensation for the extra turn just granted.

Turn sequence this lap: a's turn ends → **b goes next** (bonus turn) → **a is skipped** (chip removed) → c goes → d goes.

Demonstrates the real positive-shift boundary. Onto the marker's slot buys the next turn; across it buys an extra one, and somebody pays for it. The displaced-actor skip is compensation for that extra turn — not a rule about landing on the marker's slot. Compare Example 4, where the same displacement happens and nothing is skipped.

Example 4 — A negative shift landing exactly on the marker's slot

a, b, c, d. a plays Initiative Shift -2 on c.

c's clockwise math also lands it exactly on the marker's own slot — but because this is a *negative* shift, the boundary rule is "never sooner," and landing on the marker's slot would mean acting immediately, which is as sooner as it gets. The shift and slide happen in full: a, b, c, d becomes **c, b, d, a**. c gets a **skip chip** (not a bonus — a negative shift's target is never granted an early turn). a, displaced off the marker's slot the same way as in Example 3, gets **no chip at all**.

Turn sequence this lap: a's turn ends → **c is skipped** (chip removed) → **b goes next** → d goes → **a goes normally** when the marker reaches it.

Demonstrates the negative-shift wraparound case, and the payoff of comparing it to Example 3b: since c was skipped rather than bonus'd, there was no extra turn to compensate for — so a, despite being displaced exactly the same way, is never skipped. The displaced-actor skip only ever pairs with a bonus turn actually being granted.

Example 5 — Reshifting a token that already has a pending chip

Continuing from Example 2 (**b, d, c, a**, d holding a skip chip): during b's turn, b plays a card with Initiative Shift +1 on d.

d's pending skip chip is removed — a fresh shift on a chip-holding token cancels whatever was pending, rather than stacking or compounding it. d then resolves under the new shift on its own terms, and nothing about the cancelled chip carries into that.

Resolving it fresh means resolving it by Example 3, because that is the case it is: d sits one slot off the marker and the shift is 1, so it lands exactly on the marker's own slot and **onto is not across**. **b, d, c, a** becomes **d, b, c, a**, with **no chips on anyone**.

Turn sequence: b's turn ends → **d goes next** → b goes → c goes → a goes.

Demonstrates that reshifting a chip-holding token doesn't carry over the old shift's unresolved math — it clears the slate and resolves fresh, under whatever case the new shift actually lands in.

(History: this example originally read "d goes normally, no bonus, no skip." It was changed on 2026-09-06 to grant a bonus, on the reasoning that landing on the marker's slot was the bonus case. That reasoning is retired as of 2026-09-12 — landing on the marker's slot is a landing, and sooner/later is measured against when a token's own turn would have arrived rather than by ring position. The original reading was right.)

Example 6 — Shifting yourself on your own turn

a, b, c, d. a is acting. a plays **QUICKEN**, Initiative Shift +2 on itself.

a is standing on the marker's slot, so the distance to the marker is **zero** — and by the letter of the crossing rule, every positive shift a makes would cross it and buy an extra turn. **It does not**. Nothing carries you past a point you are standing on, and a has just acted.

Measure it where the rule says to: against when a's own next turn would have arrived. Having acted, that is after all three others. A shift of +2 makes it **two sooner** — after one other instead of three. **a, b, c, d** becomes **b, a, c, d**. No chip for anyone.

Turn sequence: a's turn ends → b goes next → **a goes again** → c → d.

Demonstrates the case the crossing rule reads backwards on. A combatant on the marker's slot is at position zero but their next turn is a full table away — read the slot as their place in the queue and every shift on them comes out inverted. The floor is acting next: a +9 here is the same as a +2, because acting after nobody at all is a bonus turn under another name.

Example 7 — Pushing back whoever is acting

a, b, c, d. a is acting and attacks b. b defends with **RETALIATE**, Initiative Shift **-1** on the attacker.

Same trap, mirrored. a has just acted, so a is already last — reading a's slot as its place in the queue says a is first, and moving a "later" would hand a an *earlier* turn.

Measured properly: a's next turn was after three others, and **-1 puts one more turn in front of it**. After four. The ring says it in two motions — a's token slides one slot along, and it is **passed over** the first time the marker reaches it.

Turn sequence: a's turn ends → b goes → **a is passed over** → c → d → b → **a goes**. Four others, where three would have gone.

-2 is after five, -3 is after six. One more person in front per point, at any table size. A large delay at a small table means being passed over more than once: at a table of three, a -3 is passed over twice and acts again after five others.

Demonstrates that a negative shift on the current actor is a later turn, not a lost one — which is why `rules/cards.md` carves initiative out of its ban on costing an enemy a whole attack. The turn arrives, and the wheel shows exactly when it will. Nobody earns a bonus turn here and no third party is skipped: that machinery belongs to a shift that crosses the marker, and standing on it is not crossing it.

What These Examples Demonstrate

- Sliding happens on every shift, boundary case or not — see Example 1.
- **Onto the marker's slot is not across it.** A positive shift that lands exactly on slot 0 just lands there, with no chip for anyone — and the token takes the next turn, because the marker belongs to a slot and hasn't finished with its own (Examples 3 and 5). Only a shift with further to travel than the distance to the marker has crossed (Example 3b).
- **Onto buys the next turn. Across buys an extra one, and the displaced actor pays for it.** That is the entire difference between the two cases.
- **Sooner and later are measured against when a token's own next turn would have arrived**, not by where it sits in the ring. Going last is not acting later.
- **Skip chip:** placed when a negative shift's math would let its target act sooner than allowed (Examples 2 and 4), and on the combatant displaced off the marker's slot when a bonus turn is granted (Example 3b).
- **Bonus chip:** placed only when a positive shift genuinely crosses the marker — its distance greater than the distance to the marker's slot. Removed once the immediate extra turn is taken.
- The displaced-actor skip (3b vs. 4) is compensation for a bonus turn actually granted — not a rule about displacement or about landing on the marker's slot.
- A chip-holding token that gets reshifted loses the old chip and resolves fresh under the new shift (Example 5).
- **A combatant shifting on their own turn is the exception, and it is not a small one** (Examples 6 and 7). They stand on the marker's slot, so its distance is zero and the crossing rule would fire on every shift they touch. Measure against when their own next turn would have arrived — after everyone else — and both directions come out right: +X is X sooner, floored at acting next; -X puts X more turns in front of theirs. No chips either way.
- **There is no table-size correction.** The old "with exactly 3 combatants, reduce X's magnitude by 1" rule is retired as of 2026-09-12. It existed because shifts near the marker were explosive, and the real cause was proximity to the

marker rather than slot count — which onto-is-not-across fixes at every size. Three on the wheel now behaves exactly like four, scaled down, and no shift is ever silently reduced to nothing.

Related Documents

- `rules/combat.md` — The Wheel: slot count, sliding, joining and leaving
- `rules/card-glossary.md` — Initiative Shift X: the full rule text these examples illustrate